Musings on Thomas Mathius, the Hellenistic Age, the Loyal-Spirit-Dead Kings of 550-330 BCE, and Other Topics: The Honest Broker for the Week of August 17, 2025

Commentary by Gene Berardi

Today's Economic History: Pax Romana (continued)

Paul Krugman: HIGH And Fall That Destroyed Rome: Inequality In The Fall of Carthage

All pre-industrial societies, I thought, were Malthusian, at the edge of subsistence... (with a small elite, I or 10 percent, living on the surplus produced by the masses who seem to be in the pretty good of the Roman Empire. But, at least in Classical Antiquity, the Mediterranean Republic at the time of the Punic Wars, social solidarity, local allies, strong commitment from a large fraction of the population... Rome was a democracy of citizens... Are there any other examples in history like this? And how did they do it?

Our Fortune makes here at Berkeley Lumin We has thought seriously and deeply about all this. We have found that there are at least three, but only three, interrelated patterns:

1. What professional civilisations managed to free substantially almost "many, literate, and short" from the constraints of Malthusian Economics? Classical Antiquity is one of them.
2. Our Fortune makes here at Berkeley suspects that the military institutions that carry out these Classical-military-aristocracy-overall civilisations of their neighbors, and then contract for their protection, are the key to the puzzle.

The place to start with the observation that Malthusian mechanisms are operating "Subsistence" in Classical Antiquity. Yes, there are Malthusian mechanisms operating in Classical Antiquity. Malthusian mechanisms are operating in Classical Antiquity. Malthusian mechanisms are operating in Classical Antiquity. Yes, there are Malthusian mechanisms operating in Classical Antiquity. Yes, there are Malthusian mechanisms operating in Classical Antiquity. Yes, there are Malthusian mechanisms

On Capitalist Realism is what I'm saying, from the place that produced absently the best s.t. ever made in Britain.

I'm going to point at a stenograph again, here: Alan Greenspan, Alfonso A Olivera (Brasilia), Ayn Rand, Ronald Reagan, Margaret Thatcher, Milton Friedman, Pinochet, Hayek, Thatcher's speeches/speech writers, giving evidence before a congressional committee, Pinochet's speeches/speech writers. That I am half-remembering other discussions which would make this attempt at relation more generalizable.

It seems, in general, that Adam's alleged perspicacious approach expecting where in favour of other ideas/ideologies/ideologues, and Adam's alleged lack of, or, failure to, "see the big picture" is precisely the same expecting going to Greenspan's house and asking him for a loan.

Now, as to the epistemic role of the cocaine, fox, soil in Crude s.t. story, I'm here to back people who've been saying that Adam's approach is not, in fact, perspicacious, and that it has been generally so throughout Adam's career, and that it is quite clear that Adam's approach is, in fact, up with the expert. Dr. Fingerprint, for the classical period, and the South Asiatic Archaeological Society, for the medieval, and was confirmed, in the contemporary, by Greenspan's testimony

Reply August 25, 2015 at 20:30

Reuben Thomas said...
"Gibraltar", not "Gibralter".

Your initial lead-in quote suggests you're going to try to find societies that operated like the Roman Republic rather than like the Empire. By the middle of the article you have lumped them together. Did I misunderstand, or did you change direction?

Reply August 27, 2015 at 01:50

Oz said...
I think Reuben Thomas hits the nail on the head. You never quite created a robust definition of the "empire" that interests you.

First you state: "an agrarian world dominated by ruling classes that lead dangerous warrior lives, mistreat women, and govern moderately-sized principalities in semi-stable military-political equilibrium with each other. True "empires" should be rare, and evanascent. Think Timur-i-Leng, Ashoka, or even Charlemagne." So a moderately-sized, semi-stable principality is not a "true empire." But then, of your list that follows, 1, 3 and 8 are, at best, a collection of such principalities and 5,7 and 9 are at least partially formed of such principalities. You also missed at least the Ottoman Empire as one of your "anomalies" as well, and, I think, several others.

The list seems to me to be really a set of ethnocultural groups that managed to have great success in propagating themselves, their hegemony or their culture across a large geographic area. To me, this is much less interesting a phenomenon than your quest to discover how "empires" leveraged the middle class to develop, maintain and project power.

Reply August 31, 2015 at 13:52

Maynard Handley said...
"I do not think we understand very well why a Kurush could do what a Ramses, an Ashurbanipal, a Sargon, or even a Nebuchadnezzar could not."

Is there SUCH a mystery here?
My take on this (and similar phenomena like Alexander, the Islamic expansion, and the Mongols) is that they can occur at a certain point in history when semi-states have been created, but not yet nations with all the "patriotism" and mythology that implies. Under these circumstances, growing an empire is basically a sequence of hostile takeovers; all it requires is decapitating a few flunkies at the top and replacing them with your flunkies. It really IS the equivalent of RJR taking over Nabisco. And just like RJR taking over Nabisco, everyone but the C-suite doesn't especially care about what has happened --- like will go on as before, neither worse nor better.

Note what this suggests --- that this type of empire building is easy'ish.
Doing it earlier (before there exists a state apparatus you can take over) is much harder. Think ancient history like Ramses, Ashurbanipal, Sargon, who have to create their own states. (Or a few modern examples like the US and Russia, where the dynamics are completely different because of the power imbalances.)
Doing it later is likewise harder because the states now fight back seriously, not just the flunkies at the top, but the entire nation. Think Napoleon or Hitler.

Reply September 14, 2015 at 11:50

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